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Does Management Performance Impact Citizen Satisfaction?

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Abstract

This article aims to examine the relationship between internal management performance and citizen satisfaction in the public sector. Top-down style evaluations emphasize improving the internal managerial performance of an agency, but few studies examine the relationship between the internal management of a governmental agency and citizen satisfaction. Our case study of government management in Seoul city attempts to address this deficiency by using data from the Seoul Service Index. Our results demonstrate a positive correlation between management performance and citizen satisfaction. We also found that the level of citizen satisfaction that helped trigger improvements in management practices varies according to the type of service. The implication of these results is that the managers of public organizations who wish to improve citizens' satisfaction with the particular service offered by their organization must seek to strategically reform their bureaucracy's internal management.

Keywords

performance management, citizen satisfaction, administrative reform

Introduction

After more than 20 years of development, management reforms and performance evaluations of public sector agencies have become widespread across the world, and recent research shows that interest in quality management and performance in the public sector continues to grow (Boyne, 2003; Pollitt & Bouckaert, 2004). The highly concentrated focus on the internal management of organizations and evaluation results, when used in conjunction with incentive systems, can help ensure that public sector agencies are as efficient as possible, since the pressure of satisfying citizens will motivate local governments' leaders and provide cues for reforming the bureaucracies.

Managerial performance is key factor in achieving better overall performance in the public sector (Meier & O'Toole, 2002), but few researchers have analyzed the relationship between managerial performance and citizen satisfaction (see Kelly 2003; Stipak, 1979). Studies on citizen satisfaction determinants focus mainly on individual, jurisdictional, and city-specific factors and neglect management factors. In other words, previous research has not paid attention to the

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impact of the public sector agencies' managerial performance on citizen satisfaction and this study contributes to research on citizen satisfaction by addressing this issue.

While there is an intuitive link between managerial performance and citizen satisfaction, it remains for the relationship to be established empirically as well as to determine the degree to which managerial performance effects satisfaction. Governments of local public organizations are appropriate entities for testing this hypothesis as they deliver public services to citizens in a limited area. In this study we explore the relationship between managerial performance and citizen satisfaction in Seoul city, Korea.

Over the past several decades, there have been ongoing efforts to design more appropriate and reliable performance measurement indicators for the public sector, and the outlook with regard to objectively, consistently, and quantifiably measuring government performance remains positive, with existing studies relying largely on benchmarking "best" practices (Bingham & Felbinger, 2002). However, among the diverse categories of performance measurement in the public sector, citizen perception of bureaucratic effectiveness remains a critical measurement component (Andrews, Boyne, Meier, O'Toole, & Walker, 2005, p. 502). Thus, this study, which focuses on the shortcomings of local government performance, is concerned with testing the degree of citizen satisfaction with regard to the services delivered by public agencies through extensive argument of the measurement issue.

Theoretical Consideration

What Determines Citizen Satisfaction?

Citizen satisfaction[1] can be defined as the combination of general and subjective assessments of the experiences people have with public services, which include not only feelings or opinions about "objective services" but also judgmental evaluations (Bouckaert & van de Walle, 2003; Kampen, van de Walle, & Bouckaert, 2006; Lee & Lee, 2006, p. 102). It follows that citizen satisfaction is not a complete variable for objectively measuring a local government's output, and the potential for the misuse of citizen satisfaction surveys for urban services as a performance indicator has been noted (Stipak, 1979). Moreover, the degree of expectation may also be a factor in determining citizen satisfaction (Van Ryzin, 2004); James (2007, p. 108), relying on the expectations approach, proved that high satisfaction with the local government's services involves low expectations, rather than simply performing public services well, while low satisfaction ratings point both to poorly performing services as well as high expectations. Brown and Coulter (1983) go farther and argue that no relationship exists between the objective status of public service delivery and citizen satisfaction, which implies that citizen satisfaction has determinants external to the delivery process (cf. Kampen et al., 2006)

Another question concerns the degree to which politicians influence citizen satisfaction with public services (cf. Garrett, Thurber, Fritschler, & Rosenbloom, 2006). On one hand, the distribution of public services is typically explained by "bureaucratic decision rules" or the "who gets what" hypothesis (Antunes & Plumlee, 1977, pp. 313-332), which reveal that government bureaucrats have greater influence than elected public officials on the decision-making processes regarding the distribution of public services (Mladenka & Hill, 1977, pp. 73-94). However, compared with the central government, local government activities are run more on administrative than political logic since the latter is responsible for delivering services directly to the citizen. Based on this fact, our study focuses on the in-workings of local government bureaucracy, presupposing that the bureaucracy determines how public services are produced and distributed within the boundary of competency.

All locally elected officials are concerned with satisfaction levels related to the services that their governments deliver, and therefore despite some complications in the use of citizen satisfaction

as a metric in the measure of bureaucratic performance, it remains a significant concept. To increase the accuracy of our metric, we rely on user surveys for our data, as opposed to data gathered from surveys administered to the citizenry in general. This choice ensures that reported levels of satisfaction are based on a subjective evaluation of the actual service by individuals who have engaged with it, rather than reactions by nonusers that reflect superficial biases (Kampen et al., 2006; Stipak, 1977), for example subjective trust in the government or views on the general effectiveness of their elected officials (Bouckaert & van de Walle, 2003). Indeed, research points to higher levels of satisfaction when services are assessed by users than when they are assessed by nonusers who do not have direct knowledge of the services in question and the performance of the bureaucrats delivering them (Andrews, Boyne, & Walker, 2006; Van Ryzin & Charbonneau, 2010).

We must also consider certain factors that influence answers on a citizen satisfaction survey. The "Personal contact model," according to Thomas (1982), which was abstracted from Lipsky (1980)'s "street-level bureaucracy," emphasizes personal interactions between bureaucrats who actually implement public services and the citizens. Lipsky found that supervisors of public housing treat the elderly better than they treat younger residents and insisted that there is a correlation between age and contact quality. Thus a satisfaction level will be determined by the way a citizen was treated by the public employee. In the same vein, Brown and Coulter (1983) and Percy (1986) discovered that satisfaction with police service is closely related to the police officer's response time and attitude but independent of a respondent's income or age. This most likely presupposes that service deliverers are seen as individuals even though no public service is actually produced by a single independent agent. In reality, every agent belongs to at least one organization or agency, and the service quality that every agent delivers might vary in relation to his or her senior managers. However, despite this critical fact, there are no studies to date that have made the impact of the management performance of an agency on citizen satisfaction their primary focus. This study contributes to research on citizen satisfaction by filling this gap.

Relating Managerial Performance to Citizen Satisfaction

New public management proponents prescribe contracting out, privatizing, or agencyifying to improve managerial performance for public service (Lane, 2009) as well as introducing Western style administrative reforms that focus on the internal management of organizations: management by objectives, incentive systems, performance evaluation, and others. Public management scholars (Boyne, 2003; Boyne, Farrell, Law, Powell, & Walker, 2003; Forbes & Lynn, 2005; Hill & Lynn, 2005; Pollitt, 2000; Pollitt & Bouckaert, 2004) have created a significant body of research on the topic of determining how best to measure and improve managerial performance, but the connection has not been made between these performance gains and their effect on citizen satisfaction (Bouckaert & van de Walle, 2003). If the effects of management can produce an objective change in the quality of service provision, it stands to reason that management will also produce an indirect effect for citizen satisfaction, and thus by focusing on the performance fluctuations in service levels per se we neglect an important dimension of managerial performance itself.

Management is an important factor in organizational performance in the sense that bureaucrats exercise discretion in the implementation of government services, and growing evidence points toward the importance of management as a determinant of organizational performance, including human resource management and managerial quality (Meier & O'Toole, 2002). Three broad types of public management constructs have been identified: administrative structures, managerial tools, and management values and strategies (Forbes, Hill, & Lynn, 2006). For this reason, the image of "galloping elephants" is considered to be a critical factor for organizational performance

(Andrews et al., 2006; Brewer & Selden, 2000). In particular, the internal management of a bureaucracy can discover unutilized potential in the workforce and help to improve the overall effectiveness of public services, as was proven in England (Audit Commission, 2003). Management's role is to make employees perform work and it consists of many components. Boyne (2003, p. 371) classified main management variables into leadership style and expertise, organizational culture, human resource management (HRM), strategy processes, and strategy content. Yet, again, the question of whether or not these management variables determine citizen satisfaction has not been fully answered.

Another problem is how to measure the performance of internal management within a bureaucracy and, furthermore, who should do it. In practice, management performance of public service providers is judged by multiple entities that include users, taxpayers, staff, and politicians. Each entity may use different criteria to judge the standard of public services and may apply different weights to the same criterion (Boschken, 1994; Boyne, 2003; Rainey, 1997), therefore the results of the evaluations have different meanings, depending on the evaluators' position.

Finally, the validity of evaluation results will be largely dependent on the availability of information. In general, the internal operation of government bureaucracy is not well known to external actors (Rainey, 1997), and therefore the internal management should be judged by those who have access to adequate internal information. This is another reason why empirical verification of the causal relationships between management and citizen satisfaction is so difficult.

Differentiating Citizen Satisfaction from Customer Satisfaction

Amidst our discussion of performance enhancement as a means of improving citizen satisfaction, it is important to delve a bit deeper into the concept of citizen satisfaction, which until now has been explained in much the same way one might describe customer satisfaction.[2] Within the public sector, customer satisfaction certainly exists, but it is differentiated from customer satisfaction in the private sector because it is supplemented by fundamental moralistic underpinnings that are embedded within the public sector (Andrews & Boyne, 2010; Waldo, 1948). Hence, this moralistic type customer satisfaction, which is particular to the public sector, may be cast as citizen satisfaction. Thus, as a result of our conceptualization of citizen satisfaction, a dual identity can be seen whereby citizens simultaneously perform both, the role of the citizen, which is influenced by citizens' moral ideals, as well as the role of the customer, which is influenced by performance, when consuming public services (Lowery, 1998; cf. Wichowski & Moynihan, 2008).

Finally, there is a temporal element to the customer and moralistic dimensions, which contribute to citizen satisfaction. Moralistic values are slow to change and can result from generations of value normalization processes (Inglehart, 2000). In contrast, organizational performance is relatively quick to respond to efforts of change, and thus constitutes the basis of major reform efforts, such as New Public Management, which seeks to improve citizen satisfaction through ameliorating the customer satisfaction dimension of citizen satisfaction.[3]

Hypotheses

The central contention of this study is as follows:

Hypothesis 1: Internal agency management strongly and positively affects citizen satisfaction as far as local government performance is concerned.

However, managerial performance will influence citizen satisfaction for different services to different degrees. According to Kelly (2003), for instance, there is no significant relationship between police and fire service performance and citizen satisfaction. Lack of correct information about police activities or cognitive and perceptive mechanisms may partially explain this gap, but whether his finding is applicable to services other than police and fire is subject to debate.

To test Hypothesis 1, therefore, it is necessary to categorize public services. We classify local public services into core and other categories based a service's level of importance in a citizen's everyday life. The list of agencies within the two categories can vary according to location due to differences in environmental features as well as the role of government with regard to the market.[4] We classify services further into universal and selective categories based on the scope of citizen served. If the beneficiary of the service is the general citizen, we classify it as universal service, and if the beneficiary of the service is a particular citizen, we classify it as selective service. The instrumental linkage between management performance and user satisfaction is likely to vary according to the nature of the services. In addition, the degree of citizen satisfaction seems to vary with the expectations and evaluation standards are different across service types.

Thus, we arrive at the next hypothesis:

Hypothesis 2: Citizen satisfaction will be different across each different type of service.

Research Design

Variables and Model

The case for this study is Seoul Metropolitan City in Korea. The population of Seoul Metropolitan City area is more than 10 million, and although Korea used to be a highly centralized country, reforms in 1994 in favor of decentralization brought elections to local governments and consequently cities have had more potential to independently improve service quality. The Seoul Metropolitan City government partially oversees the 25 district governments representing the lower tier of local governments. Both city government and district governments are governed by mayors and local councils constituted by direct citizen suffrage.

Seoul is a good case for identifying the causal relationship between managerial performance and citizen satisfaction since it necessitates fewer control variables. Service districts are basically coterminous across service agencies and areas, which makes it easier to relate managerial responsibility to performance. Moreover, the population of Seoul is dominated by a single ethnic group, and consequently problems related to representative bureaucracy and its relationship to achieving high performance, for instance those discovered by Andrews et al. (2005) in the case of English local governments, will not be factors. Furthermore, governments play a monopolist role in providing public services, which means that citizen's perceptions of services are likely to come from the service outputs that governments deliver.

The dependent variable of this study is the level of citizen satisfaction, or user satisfaction more precisely. To measure this variable, we used the Seoul Service Quality Index (SSQI) as a proxy variable. SSQI has its roots in the concept of service quality (cf. Zeithaml, Berry, & Parasuraman, 1988), which evaluates citizens' perceived quality of public services. SSQI measures the current quality of service and provides information on quality dimensions that require improvement.

The elements of citizen satisfaction to be measured were determined after considering theoretical models such as the SERVQUAL model as well as previous research done in Korea on this issue: process quality, outcome quality, service environment quality, and social quality

Table 1. Dimensions and Components of SSQI

Dimension	Components
Process quality	Speed
	Credibility
	Kindness
Outcome quality	Satisfaction
	Likeability
Office environment quality	Amenity
	Convenience
	Aesthetics
Social quality	Consideration for socially weak groups
	Security and safety

Note: SSQI = Seoul Service Quality Index.

(Seoul City Government, 2005; See table 1). Process quality measures the quality of service that citizens experienced in the process of using the service, while output quality is the quality satisfaction level that citizens feel after they have finished using the service. Office environment quality refers to the quality level citizens experienced regarding the environment and atmosphere in which the service is administered. Social quality deals with quality in terms of the public aspect of the service and includes both equity, for example, "Were all customers treated equally?" and security, for example, "Did the agency make efforts to insure the customers' security and safety?"

The independent variable is the level of performance of management in public organization units that produce or deliver services. Theoretically, management factors such as leadership, resources, and the relationship between providers and customers will affect citizen satisfaction. First, the executive management's personal concern for motivating personnel can be expressed as enhanced leadership, and these managers will be able to encourage their personnel to act in a citizen-friendly manner by using incentives. This personal trait shown by managers influences public employees both directly and indirectly and leads them to work toward greater citizen satisfaction. Second, the resources an organization is in charge of greatly affects citizen satisfaction. Human resources, material resources, and the power to influence the performance of an organization and to secure these resources demonstrates just how important the interest and weight of citizen satisfaction is to specific organizations. Third, organizations that not only cultivate good relations with service recipients but also foster good internal relationships between employees will produce higher levels of citizen satisfaction. By participatory management, for instance, difficulties that employees face can be understood by citizens and conversely public organizations can better understand the needs of citizens through citizen participation, an understanding which ultimately leads to greater citizen satisfaction. Finally, the process itself, for example, the duration of the transaction, is an important factor in the service industry (Davis & Vollmann, 1990; Dube-Rioux, Schmitt, & Leclerc, 1989). An example of this would be "being served on time," which is likely to increase customer satisfaction. However, bureaucracy possesses a distinguishing characteristic in this regard in that it tends to complicate the speedy delivery of goods and services for various reasons. This is why many administrative reforms target bureaucratic inertia, which results most often in restructuring processes.

For measuring management performance, this study relies on the Seoul Service Potential Index (SSPI). SSPI evaluates an organization's internal service capacity, which presumably influences SSQI. In other words, SSPI measures an organization's internal capacity, something invisible to ordinary citizens, and which thereby allows us to infer the root causes of service problems. SSPI

Table 2. Dimensions and Components of SSPI

Dimension	Components
Leadership	Leadership strategies & planning
Resources	Human resources
	Knowledge resources
	Material resources & budget
Relationship	Citizen relationship
	Partner firm relationship
	Community relationship
Process	Process management
	Process improvement

Note: SSPI = Seoul Service Potential Index.

also signifies "the potential for an organization" to provide high quality services in the future; hence the name "service potential." SSPI consists of four dimensions: leadership of the manager(s), resources, relationships with different stakeholders, and processes of the bureaucracy's internal operation, each dimension having three to five components for measurement (See table 2).

In addition to these dependent and independent variables, we need to select typical public services to test Hypothesis 2 so as to examine differences in satisfaction level by service type. In Korea, important services such as police, fire fighting, education, and parks are either national or highly standardized due to the strong intervention of the central government. Furthermore, data availability limited this study to public affairs (referred to as PA below), household waste collection (referred to as WC below), and public health centers (referred to as PHC below) for the data analysis.[5] The term "public affairs" in the Korean public sector refers to all types of authorization, certification, or petitions, which are important issues for ordinary citizens, as Korea is a heavily administrated society.

Testing a causal relationship requires controlling other variables, which may affect the relationship. As Williams (1971) and Bolotin and Cingranelli (1983) pointed out, public service quality can vary according to the economic situation of the location, which in turn will affect citizen satisfaction levels. Moreover, there are theoretical explanations of factors influencing citizen satisfaction. Some focus on the individual-level demographics (e.g., race and income) and attitudinal (e.g. political efficacy) factors. Literature related to urban politics suggests that city-specific roles of leaders in providing objective conditions in urban governance would be conducive to citizen satisfaction (Dehoog et al., 1990). Other factors influence citizen satisfaction with public services, among which are regional characteristics, objective level of actual public service distribution, socioeconomic status, and subjective psychological status of the citizens.

To control for the variable of living conditions, this study included population density, population growth, and the amount of local taxes paid per person as control variables. This model is closely related to the study of the class bias model and is similar contextually to the underclass hypothesis, suggesting that citizens surrounded by lower class neighborhoods would not have enough means to intervene in policy processes and to demonstrate their interests effectively and are therefore discriminated against in the distribution of public services when compared to citizens in upper class neighborhoods (Bolotin & Cingranelli, 1983, pp. 209-219). Even though all the districts of Seoul City are relatively demographically and ethnically homogeneous when compared to other metropolitan cities of the world, the level of citizen wealth and that of living conditions for each district are slightly different.

Considering these factors, we performed a multiple regression analysis to test the above hypothesis. The analytical model is as follows:

Table 3. Comparison of Data Collection Methods Between SSPI and SSQI

	SSPI	SSQI
Evaluator	Expert	Citizen
Sampling	Selection of evaluation targets	Random sampling of citizens who have already used the government service
Evaluation tool	Actual inspection by evaluation checklist	Structured questionnaire

Note: SSPI = Seoul Service Potential Index; SSQI = Seoul Service Quality Index.

$$\text{Citizen (User) Satisfaction} = f(\text{management performance, service type, population density, population growth, and local taxes paid per person})$$

Incidentally, two dummy variables are also used in the regression model for testing the differences among the three types of local government services.

Data: Seoul Service Index (SSI)

Inspired by Western practices, an evaluation framework and methodology called the Seoul Service Index, (SSI), which is composed of SSPI and SSQI, was developed in 2003 and is continually being improved each year. This index aims to measure the services delivered by the 25 district governments to make the city better for its citizens. Data spanning a 3-year period, from 2003 to 2005, for each district's government is used to maintain the homogeneity of the data set since the evaluation criteria and scales have been slightly modified over the years.

Each of the four dimensions of SSQI, process quality, outcome quality, service environment quality, and social quality contains three to five components whose numbers vary only slightly year after year. Each component has two to five questions, but their total number is slightly different from one year to another. A question addressing the overall satisfaction with the component (To what degree are you satisfied with the staff's kindness?) was asked because the true overall satisfaction level with services depends on the surveyed person's memory about the overall experience. Also, participants were asked to weigh the relative importance of each of the components within each dimension. Questions about citizen satisfaction were answered from *very dissatisfied* to *very satisfied* and were ranked according to the 7-point Likert-type scale. The survey results were then converted into an aggregated score.[6] The conduction of the surveys was outsourced to four private companies that included Gallup Korea.

The total size of samples allocated evenly to each district varies from 1,600 to 3,000, according to the service type and year of survey: for example, 3,000 households (120 random samples for 25 districts) answered the customer satisfaction survey concerning Household Waste Collections in 2004, while 2,000 citizens (72 random samples for 25 district Healthcare users and 8 residents in each of the 25 districts) answered the questionnaire regarding the health services quality in 2003.

The data used for the independent variables are of the same nature as the dependent variables with any differences being caused by the improvement of measurements during the year. Because these components are not visible to the ordinary citizen, they are evaluated by panel experts based on documents and participatory observation. Twenty experts reviewed all the documents submitted by the district governments and visited the offices to collect field information (See table 3).

The four dimensions of SSPI, leadership, resources, relationships, and processes, include three to five components that each have two to five questions. For example, the measurement indicator of Public Affairs in 2003 has 38 detailed questions. One sample question about the leadership is

"How clearly did the leader express the unit's vision and mission to his or her subordinates?" Each dimension consists of 250 points, which are evenly divided among each question, thus resulting in question values ranging from 22.7 to 31.7 points. A simple average score, based on the panel experts' total evaluation, represents the SSPI score for the district.

The data for the 25 districts' managerial performance scores (Seoul Service Potential Index, SSPI) and public service performance scores (Seoul Service Quality Index, SSQI) were obtained from the documents provided to the researchers by the Performance Review Team of Seoul Metropolitan City Government as well as from its official web site. This study used the averages or aggregated scores calculated using the formula explained above for each district, which means the total number of observations is 75: 3 years of data, for each of the 25 districts, for each variable. Because the data is slightly different from one year to another in terms of questions, as well as the sampling method, this study uses multiple regression models, assuming questions from successive years are independent.[7]

Findings

The result in Table 4 shows that SSPI has a positive and statistically significant effect on SSQI within the significance level of .001. Thus the higher the performance management level of a district government is, the higher the level of user satisfaction regarding the service provided by that government. Specifically, managers who pay more attention to leadership, relationships, resources, and processes, qualities which correspond to the management components of Boyne's (2003, p. 371) study, achieve higher levels of citizen satisfaction for their service delivery.

Table 4. Regression of SSQI on SSPI by Service Type

	Coefficient	*SE*	Beta
Constant	53.509***	3.664	
SSPI	0.185***	0.045	0.242***
Public Health Care	7.845***	0.937	0.542
Civil Affairs	2.105*	0.969	0.146*
Population density	0.000*	0.000	0.115*
Population growth	–0.134	0.297	–0.026
local tax amount per person	0.591	0.453	0.087
R^2/Adjusted R^2		.562/0.316	
F value		16.795***	

Note: SSQI = Seoul Service Quality Index; SSPI = Seoul Service Potential Index.
*Significant at .05 level. **Significant at .01 level. ***Significant at .001 level.

The citizen-as-consumer model uses performance measures to maximize service effectiveness, advocating the use of internal and external performance checks to reinvent government (Osborne & Gaebler, 1992). These NPM-styled reform ideas implicitly assumed that improvements in service performance along some measurable dimensions would be reflected in increased consumer satisfaction. This study's result clarifies the argument that better internal management leads to better administrative performance.

Methodologically, this study used data that directly and accurately measured its target objective: internal management was rated by expert panels, while citizen satisfaction levels were rated by randomly sampled citizens who had used the government service of interest. This is a significant improvement regarding the methodological problem of measuring such a subjective type of

relationship; however, in this study we did not take into consideration the expectation level that James (2007) pointed out as far as the measure of customer satisfaction is concerned.

External measures of service effectiveness coming from citizens, usually through satisfaction surveys, are problematic for administrators because it is unclear what criteria the citizens are using to evaluate effectiveness, and therefore the amount of accurate information citizens have on which to base their evaluations is questionable (Kelly & Swindell, 2002, p. 610). However, according to Percy (1986) and Stipak (1979), citizen surveys may yield meaningful results when the questions related to service quality are specific and directly tied to personal experience. Given these constraints, this study uses a measure of citizen satisfaction that was carefully designed, to reflect the Seoul city governments' service qualities.

Regarding the control variable, only population density has proven to be significant in our regression model. Unlike the research of Kelly (2003), which focuses exclusively on elements within local governments, population density has proven to be an essential parameter to include when comparing local government performance. District areas of Seoul city share in common the fact that they are geographic regions within the city of Seoul, often with some topographic features that distinguish them from other areas. The differences in service satisfaction across geographic areas would be even more pronounced the more the surveyed areas resembled what a layperson would consider residential areas. As Andrews et al. (2005) argued, the more heterogeneous a local government's clients are, the more difficult it will be for the local government to match their preferences. In the same vein, Swindell and Kelly (2005) tested the hypothesis that the traditional socioeconomic and demographic variables play a role in explaining citizen satisfaction to the core local government's services, while factors like age and gender seem to have ambiguous influences, with studies producing conflicting results. (James, 2007, p. 111)

Seoul is a highly congested area where the socioeconomic, as well as demographic conditions, are relatively homogeneous across the district areas. As the capital city of Korea, service is the dominant industry in Seoul; therefore population density is a concise indicator, which can be used to explain the differences in living conditions among the areas inside the city. Individuals' sense of attachment to their district and expectations of efficiency from their government are relatively strong, and after the decentralization reforms introduced in 1994, district governments started to compete with each other to provide better living environments to their residents. Unlike other metropolitan cities in the world, the districts of Seoul city do not show significant disparity, in the sense that there are not extremely poor areas, which is the reason why only population density is significant as a control variable, while economic standing (tax per capita) is not. In other words, this can be interpreted from the particularity of the physiognomy of Seoul city.

We can also say that Hypothesis 1 holds true in Korean administrative culture, which can be characterized as having a top-down implementation tradition and a state-driven society, thus making governments the most influential players. In Korea, governments resemble monopolies in their provision of public services, indicating that the possibility exists to improve user satisfaction without relying on NPM reforms such as privatization. Citizen expectations of the government in Korea are greater than in other countries where the role of government in the society is not supposed to be high (Cho & Im, 2010), and there is little possibility that those who answered the citizen satisfaction survey have confused the government-provided service under evaluation with other services.

It is also interesting to consider the results concerning the variations in relationships among service types. These results relate to Kelly (2003), who found no statistically significant relationship between the objective performance indicator and citizen satisfaction in the fields of police and fire. When we set waste collection as a reference group using two dummy variables, both public health care and civil affairs services have a significant impact on citizen satisfaction, which means that Hypothesis 2 is also acceptable. It is worth noticing the coefficients of the

independent variables shown in Table 4 to understand the strength of the relationship between management and citizen satisfaction proved in the test of Hypothesis 1 by the service category.

We also observe that the degree of the management's impact on citizen satisfaction found in the field of public health care service is higher than that of waste collection services. Each district government in Seoul runs a public health care center that delivers basic medical services, especially to lower class citizens. In the wealthy districts, citizens normally go to private clinics, while in the poorer districts more citizens use public health centers, which are cheaper and even provide free treatment at times. Ironically, the rich district governments tend to invest more in their public heath care services to attract more citizens, for example, by providing Traditional Oriental medicine, or by specializing in senior citizens' clinics. This is understandable, because the rich districts have more financial resources than the poorer districts, and there are fewer patients in the rich areas. This larger organizational slack, when combined with good management, allows a better service score, which results in higher user satisfaction. In fact, in this sector it is clear that citizen satisfaction is largely determined by the service quality that doctors and nurses deliver. This study's results imply that the level of client satisfaction of personalized services, such as public health care, can be increased by improving the internal performance of the medical center.

The field of "public affairs" services reveals a second strong positive relationship between the level of management and customer satisfaction. Civil affairs services are a particular service type that best characterize the tools available to the Korean government: as a highly administrative state, there are a large number of bureaucratic regulations that require citizens to visit their local government offices to obtain permits and certificates, such as citizen identification cards, marriage registration certificates, vehicle registration certificates, local taxes, or to obtain passports, social welfare, and so on. Most citizens who use these services have general dislike of visiting government offices and as such presumably already have a negative attitude toward the agent who is dealing with their affairs, as in the bureaucratic dysfunctions described by Lipsky (1980) and Merton (1957). For this reason, many mayors are concerned with the quality of offices that citizens visit for public affairs purposes and hold regular evaluations of the staff in charge. Motivated by these concerns, some districts transformed their front offices into lobbies rivaling luxurious hotels, but more commonly measures have been introduced to monitor customer waiting time and agent hospitality. Another common reform has been the introduction of "one stop service" goals, which project a maximum of 30 min waiting time for citizens receiving civil affairs services. This study's results reveal that such reform measures, which target bureaucratic inertia as well as uneven allocation of resources among agencies and services, have a positive effect on citizen satisfaction.

Management and citizen satisfaction are also positively correlated in the field of waste collection. Household waste collection is a concrete and simple service that allows a clear measure of quality, as James (2007, p. 109) pointed out. Every district government actually outsourced the execution of waste collection, but the private companies which were awarded the contracts are not in a competitive environment; instead, this type of service is conducted much in the same way it was before being outsourced, due to the government agency's close control of the companies. Streets in Seoul are, in general, clean, and a call system for cleaning problems functions well. Therefore the service quality among districts does not vary much and management performance still plays a role.

Theoretically, these three services are different in terms of frequency of use and coverage of users. An ordinary citizen uses each service with varying frequency across service types. The order, from most frequently used to least frequently used, is waste collection, civil affairs, and public health care. In terms of coverage of the service, waste collection is the most universal service and public health care is the most selective service. The marginal impact of frequent services is low and consequently citizens give that kind of service low evaluations. In contrast, less frequently

used services like public health care have a big marginal impact, so citizens evaluate them highly. This provides a clue for us to understand the disconnect between the actual performance of a service and the results of citizen satisfaction surveys that Brown and Coulter pointed out (1983).

Discussion

Why the rush to satisfy citizens in many countries such as Korea, where traditionally public servants have occupied authoritarian roles vis-à-vis those whom they serve? What are conditions for using the performance management or performance evaluation, in particular, to find better ways to serve the public or to make the bureaucrats who have in the past been criticized for their inefficiency and insensitivity to work better to meet the people's needs?

Furthermore, what conditions can be considered instrumental in better satisfying citizens in terms of performance management?

Surely external pressure is a determinant factor to make local politicians be interested in performance management and more particularly a gamut of performance assessments. Democratization movement, which empowered citizens, notably through the elections, led mayors to be, to some extent, "political entrepreneur" to please the electorate. E-government also contributed the enhanced citizen awareness of their local government performance as well as feedback. Regardless of the reforms' true effects, mayors are more likely to be interested in performance management for, at least, showing its success as a political symbolic gesture (Im, 2007). Not only transparency about the management via citizen satisfaction survey, for example, but also exposure to mass media local government's performance is related to this trend to the democratization. Reversely, multiplication of media coverage about the government's performance is associated with the degree of democratization.

The democratic operation of local government machine, which might be measured by the proliferation of PARTs, for example, is just a necessary condition to make it an effective bureaucracy for the citizen's needs. The satisfactory condition is how to make the bureaucrats accept the new instrument(s) that they are not ready to accept. There are three mechanisms that made this possible; coercive force, favorable social atmosphere, and monetary incentive.

The coercive force by the central government is a steady condition found in the Korean case. Basic Law of Government Policy Evaluation, which was adopted in 2001, clearly mandates that the implementation processes of major government policies in local governments be evaluated each year by the Prime Minister's office. In fact, about 200 different kinds of performance evaluations were already in use by Korean local governments by the year 2000 (Research Center for Korea National Audit, 2006). In addition to this phenomenal increase of evaluations imposed by central government evaluation, many local governments as well as other actors such as NGOs have introduced other evaluations on their own initiatives.

This multiplication of evaluation generates the supporting social atmosphere, which is critical for fighting closed and authoritarian bureaucracy left in a new democracy. For example, the Seoul city government has been conducting the Seoul Survey, as shown above. Also NGOs,[8] and media outlets occasionally administer evaluation programs, especially during the local election year, to inform citizens of their local government's performance. All of these evaluation programs are characterized by external forces whose reputation validate, to the eyes of citizen, rank of the lower local governments in relation to each other.

Participation in this kind of evaluation programs is not compulsory, but almost all local governments tend to volunteer to be evaluated because the simple fact of not being in the list of volunteered local governments risk the mayor(s) to lose face to the citizen. Once a mayor is personally concerned with a particular evaluation program, he or she attempts to lead employees to a greater organizational commitment to achieve a better score on the performance evaluation.

A relatively poor score on a performance evaluation leads to a loss of face for the mayor heading the district.

The nature of intergovernmental relations transforms from formal and hierarchical mechanisms to incentive based mechanisms. This was unavoidable, because the hierarchical relationship between Seoul city government and its district governments has been evolving into a more equal partnership since decentralization reforms in 1994 placed elected officials in the posts previously occupied by appointees. Nevertheless, the central city government continues to control the resources that districts need and distribution is largely based on the results of the performance evaluations of district governments. In this system district governments compete with each other to obtain more financial support from the central city government. This shift of strategies is particularly significant because mayors of the various district governments are encouraged to do their best to satisfy their constituents by providing increasingly better services via the better management of their agencies.

According to interviews with city employees, Seoul Survey studies above is considered *the* most powerful tool among many evaluation programs. The evaluation results that this study relied on are different in that Seoul city government awards 100 to 200 million Korean Won (equivalent to US$100,000 to US$200,000) to the best performing district governments. The size of this financial incentive is not negligible since each district government has only a very small margin of budgetary discretion. In addition, the awarded district governments always advertise their success widely to the citizens and success is considered important for district mayors aiming for reelection.

Another point to discuss here is conditions of PART as the instrument to link between managerial performance and organizational effectiveness, that is, citizen satisfaction. With the rapidly western style democratization, Korea became a laboratory for various PARTs and managerial techniques. The first trend in this new business is the proliferation of the Korean style PART,[9] which is causing increases to not only the number of evaluations but also the number of evaluation criteria used in each evaluation program. The second trend is a desire for perfection in the rating system: after implementing a performance evaluation, the evaluators assess the evaluation itself in an effort to discover weaknesses and areas for improvement. The designers of the evaluations are continually adding new measurements, for instance, by combining subjective and objective evaluations as well as by inserting new data and information obtained from local government employees.

The crucial condition for success is that managers become personally interested in the evaluative process, an assertion that accords with Brewer and Selden (2000)'s characterization of the central problems of bureaucracy. Progress toward this goal might be aided by a simplification of the PARTs such that only the most effective tools are used while those with limited utility are eliminated. If the current level of complication remains, the potential of the evaluation index to fundamentally improve the performance of the bureaucracy may remain a possibility only, with the only practical effect being the increasing fatigue of the subjects of evaluation (Im, 2010).

In contexts other than Korea, the complexity of government activities is a hindrance to apply this study's finding. Much of the literature on the government performance suggests that the diversity of government action creates difficulties for the accurate measurement of performance (Behn, 2003; Sanger, 2008; Smith, 2009). Moreover, government objectives are often varied and ambiguous, which can further complicate measurement. A clear statement of goals, with quantified performance indicators, must necessarily precede measurements of performance, for the reason that no single "magic performance measure" can have universal application. If performance is to be measured, it must be done so only relative to particular objectives; "Only then can [managers] select measures with the characteristics necessary to help achieve each purpose." (Behn, 2003, p. 586)

Conclusion

This article contributes to elucidate the common sense–like presupposition about the impact of managerial improvement on the citizen satisfaction. Methodological issue, especially regarding the difficulty of measuring the managerial performance, was cautiously treated to test the hypothesis. We tested target effects in a model that provided a high level of statistical explanation and can therefore be reasonably confident that the findings related to this target regime are robust. Because of the special features of Seoul, there were fewer variables to control in identifying causal link between managerial performance and citizen satisfaction. Moreover, the multiyear data set that we relied on cancels out yearly distortion, and the multiservice data set helps to identify a pattern in service delivery across services.

The relationship between managerial performance and user satisfaction proved above can be supported on the basis that that Korean bureaucracies are as well managed, with interactions between superiors and subordinates in the hierarchy being relatively intense since the 1960s and management reforms an ordinary way of life. Keeping the hierarchical form of organization, Korean governments nevertheless undergo continual reforms of their internal management (cf. Hill & Lynn, 2005), not hesitating to draw on both homegrown as well as imported operational policies. In addition to being well managed, Korean bureaucracy is relatively efficient due to its self-learning organization style. Consequently, the level of local government competency in Korea is largely determined by the human resource management factor (Lee, 2008).

To apply performance management in other countries, the problem is related more to how to integrate in the findings of evaluation studies in such a way that organizations remain adaptive to their environments but managers do not exclude employees from making effective changes for the betterment of the organization. This relates to training them on how to interpret and thoughtfully implement the findings.

Especially the reform should target to empower all personnel, the rank and file in particular. Many managerial reforms failed just because only upper middle managers are concerned while the rest of the organization feels indifferent. In Seoul districts cases, the successful mayors managed to encourage their personnel to improve their performances by any means at their disposal, such as employee bonuses or faster promotions. In other words, the empowerment enhanced by all means increases employees' organizational citizenship, which results in a successful managerial reform.

Finally, it is worth considering whether these findings can be generalized and applied to other countries, insofar as our study has focused in depth on a single city and does not attempt to incorporate data from alternative sources. With some reservation, we contend that the result is applicable to other cities of other countries, especially many developing countries that are in the transition stage from traditional authoritarian regime to democracy by introducing western style managerial reforms, for example, many Asian countries such as China. Also the conditions for a successful PART and performance management reform discussed above can be applicable and testable to many western local cities. However, organizational culture and managerial practices in the public sector vary by nation, and to determine the extent to which national culture affects the link between management performance and citizen satisfaction, an international comparative study is necessary.

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Notes

1. According to Lee & Lee (2006, pp. 101-102), satisfaction is a psychological state formed through experiences of public services offered by public institutions or shaped by subjective psychological phenomena. Second, satisfaction is a response of assessment comparing suitability of norms for the object of public services. Third, satisfaction is necessarily formed on the basis of expectation or experiences. Fourth, satisfaction is collective in point of assessment and it reflects all aspects of several experiences. Fifth, satisfaction is a dynamic phenomenon that varies as time passes in the process of evaluation which produces satisfaction from empirical input. Finally, satisfaction is a citizen's perception of the degree to which the citizen's demand and desire have been fulfilled.
2. Citizen satisfaction is very similar to customer satisfaction, with expectancy disconfirmation playing a major role in the description and assessment of both types of satisfaction (Kampen et al., 2006; Spreng, MacKenzie, Olshavsky, 1996; Tse & Wilton, 1988; Van Ryzin, 2004).
3. Wichowski and Moynihan (2008) make a similar argument. They claim that *how* performance enhancements are achieved (operationalized as procedural justice, equity, conditions of service) will affect "end outcomes" of citizenship, which consists of social trust and civic engagement, political efficacy, and political participation.
4. Core services, necessary for human existence, are required to be supplied in a stable manner by local governments (e.g. police, fire, hygiene, water, park, road, education). Secondary services are not necessary for sustaining human life, and thus are not required to be supplied directly by local government: for instance, libraries, cultural activities, senior citizen welfare, economic development, health services, housing services, mental health services, or juvenile welfare (Fossett, 1983; Lee, 2008; Rich, 1982).
5. The Seoul Public Quality Evaluation Report (2003-2005) states that the agencies in charge of services such as police are central government's, or completely separate from the local governments; this is the reason why they are not included in this model. In addition to the service types included in this study, the report includes other services such as construction and housing.
6. SSQI of a respondent was calculated in a successive way of weighting as follows:

$$SSQI = \sum WD_k * D_k,$$

while WD_k : weight of k dimension and D_k: score of k dimension.

$$D_k = \sum WC_j * C_j,$$

while C_j : score of j component and WC_j: weight of j component.

$$\text{And } C_k = \sum I_i * G_j$$

while I_i:average score of i question belonging to j component and G_j : overall satisfaction for j component.
7. A panel analysis was also attempted, but the results of the coefficient were very similar to the regression results. However the result of the F-test for no fixed effect and the Hausman test implied that the panel model is not suitable in this case.
8. Unlike the USA PART, the evaluation framework of PART in Korea is centrally decided with the participation of lower governments or agencies to be evaluated, experts, and representatives of citizens.
9. In South Korea, nongovernmental organizations (NGOs) are predominantly politically oriented and are rarely service oriented.
10. In addition, we cannot rule out the lingering possibility of reverse causality in the relationship between managerial factors and citizen satisfaction.

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